

The Open Boat

Stephen Crane · 1897

First published: Scribner's, Jun 1897

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Cambridge International edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Cover: Claude Monet, The Magpie (1868–1869). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Open_Boat (revision 13921851), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Open Boat suggest about nature's indifference?
- What does The Open Boat suggest about brotherhood?
- What does The Open Boat suggest about survival?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Cambridge International

CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5

Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Open Boat	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*nature's indifference* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Open Boat

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Stephen Crane's life or times connects to nature's indifference in “The Open Boat”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (nature's indifference, brotherhood, survival).

Standards: Cambridge International: see the unit standards

Author biography

Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28.

Historical and cultural context

On 2 January 1897 the steamer SS Commodore, carrying arms to Cuban rebels fighting Spain, sank off Florida. Crane, aboard as a correspondent, spent about thirty hours in a ten-foot dinghy with the captain, the cook and an oiler, Billie Higgins, who drowned in the surf. The story is based on that ordeal.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Scribner's Magazine in June 1897, subtitled "A Tale Intended to be after the Fact. Being the Experience of Four Men from the Sunk Steamer Commodore."

Then: Admired by writers including Joseph Conrad and H. G. Wells.

Now: A central work of American naturalism and one of the great sea stories.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Four men (the captain, the cook, the oiler and the correspondent) row a small boat through heavy seas toward the Florida coast after their ship sinks.

Main themes

- nature's indifference.
- brotherhood.
- human fragility.

Why it matters

It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.

Spoilers · teacher only

When they finally swim for shore, the strongest, the oiler, drowns; the others survive and feel they can now be "interpreters" of the sea.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Open Boat: When have you worked with others to survive a hard situation?
Prompt: Before we open The Open Boat: When have you worked with others to survive a hard situation?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
naturalism; irony; point of view; imagery.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28. The world of the book. On 2 January 1897 the steamer SS Commodore, carrying arms to Cuban rebels fighting Spain, sank off Florida. Crane, aboard as a correspondent, spent about thirty hours in a ten-foot dinghy with the captain, the cook and an oiler, Billie Higgins, who drowned in the surf. The story is based on that ordeal. Publication and reception. Published in Scribner's Magazine in June 1897, subtitled "A Tale Intended to be after the Fact. Being the Experience of Four Men from the Sunk Steamer Commodore." Then: Admired by writers including Joseph Conrad and H. G. Wells. Now: A central work of American naturalism and one of the great sea stories.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" slowly and put it in my own words: None of the men in the dinghy knows what color the sky is. Next, craft. I notice the sky, normally the biggest thing in view, is the thing they cannot see. The strongest word is "sky": naming what they miss tells us how closely they must watch the sea. Then, effect. What does this opening sentence tell us about the men's situation? My answer: The men are in such danger that beauty and distance have disappeared; Crane puts us inside the boat at wave level from the first line.

> *NONE of them knew the color of the sky (The Open Boat, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" slowly and put it in my own words: None of the men in the dinghy knows what color the sky is. Next, craft. I notice the sky, normally the biggest thing in view, is the thing they cannot see. The strongest word is "sky": naming what they miss tells us how closely they must watch the sea. Then, effect. What does this opening sentence tell us about the men's situation? My answer: The men are in such danger that beauty and distance have disappeared; Crane puts us inside the boat at wave level from the first line.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Four men (the captain, the cook, the oiler and the correspondent) row a small boat through heavy seas toward the Florida coast after their ship sinks. Themes to track: nature's indifference.: brotherhood.: human fragility.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: brotherhood. Prediction: four men in a small dinghy off the Florida coast will depend on each other to survive the waves. Question: what will they learn about nature and about one another?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Open Boat: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: brotherhood. Prediction: four men in a small dinghy off the Florida coast will depend on each other to survive the waves. Question: what will they learn about nature and about one another?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Open Boat still matter? It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.
Anchor question: Why might The Open Boat still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Crane survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897 and spent about thirty hours in a dinghy. How might that experience shape this story? Answer: Accept answers such as: the details are drawn from what he lived; he shows nature as indifferent, not cruel; the story is close to his newspaper account of the wreck.
Exit ticket: Crane survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897 and spent about thirty hours in a dinghy. How might that experience shape this story?
Answer: Accept answers such as: the details are drawn from what he lived; he shows nature as indifferent, not cruel; the story is close to his newspaper account of the wreck.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Open Boat.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Stephen Crane" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Stephen-Crane); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/); Crane's newspaper report "Stephen Crane's Own Story" (New York Press, 7 January 1897)

Lesson 2: The Open Boat

Focus: brotherhood against an indifferent sea

Objective: Students will analyze how point of view develops in “The Open Boat” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Cambridge International: see the unit standards

Content note (drowning, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Drowning. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…judged well and ill of all men. Everybody took a drink of water. "COOK," remarked the captain,…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes drowning.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run the surf; the oiler, the strongest, drowns. The survivors feel they can now be 'interpreters' of the sea's voice.

Background: Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.'

Significance: A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to nature's indifference because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes drowning.
Prompt: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to nature's indifference because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: nature is "flatly indifferent."

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: paddling — propel with a paddle; oarsman — someone who rows a boat; epithets — a defamatory or abusive word or phrase; unconcern — lack of worry or interest; bequeathed — leave or give by will after one's death. "unconcern": Origin: an English formation from un- + concern.
Words: paddling: propel with a paddle · oarsman: someone who rows a boat · epithets: a defamatory or abusive word or phrase · unconcern: lack of worry or interest · bequeathed: leave or give by will after one's death

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.' A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent. Point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Imagery: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Irony: The strongest man dies. Watch for the boat: the shared human condition.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" slowly and put it in my own words: The four shipwrecked men in the small boat never look up, so none of them knows the color of the sky. Next, craft. I notice the sentence opens with a capitalized "NONE," stressing that all of them, without exception, are absorbed. The strongest word is "NONE": the capitals make the word land like a blow and include every man in the boat. Then, effect. Why does the story begin with what the men did not know? My answer: The story begins with what the men did not know because they could see only the waves that might kill them; Crane shows that survival narrows the men's whole world to the next few feet of water.

> *NONE of them knew the color of the sky (The Open Boat, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" slowly and put it in my own words: The four shipwrecked men in the small boat never look up, so none of them knows the color of the sky. Next, craft. I notice the sentence opens with a capitalized "NONE," stressing that all of them, without exception, are absorbed. The strongest word is "NONE": the capitals make the word land like a blow and include every man in the boat. Then, effect. Why does the story begin with what the men did not know? My answer: The story begins with what the men did not know because they could see only the waves that might kill them; Crane shows that survival narrows the men's whole world to the next few feet of water.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Theme. Look at the craft: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Ask: How does this line connect to nature's indifference? Expected: Nature is "flatly indifferent." (Theme.)

> *But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent (The Open Boat, paragraph 207)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Theme. Look at the craft: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.
Ask: How does this line connect to nature's indifference?
Expected answer: Nature is "flatly indifferent." (Theme.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. When the text says "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207), it shows this directly. The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. When the text says "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207), it shows this directly. The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive? Ask: what does the brotherhood in the boat mean?
Anchor question: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
Facilitation: Ask: what does the brotherhood in the boat mean?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. ("But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent", The Open Boat, paragraph 207). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. ("But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent", The Open Boat, paragraph 207). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Key takeaway: nature is "flatly indifferent."

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.
- **Imagery:** Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.
- **Irony:** The strongest man dies.

Themes and how they develop

- **nature's indifference:** nature is "flatly indifferent."

Symbols and motifs

- **the boat:** the shared human condition.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) Focus on survival.
- "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) Theme.
- "they felt that they could then be interpreters" (The Open Boat, paragraph 243) The ending.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other.
Evidence: "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207)

Reasoning: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
paddling (verb)	propel with a paddle	*"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.*	
oarsman (noun)	someone who rows a boat	*Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.*	
epithets (noun)	a defamatory or abusive word or phrase	*Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.*	
unconcern (noun)	lack of worry or interest	*It is, perhaps, plausible that a man in this situation, impressed with the unconcern of the universe, should see the innumerable flaws of his life and have them taste wickedly in his mind and wish for another chance.*	“unconcern”: Origin: an English formation from un- + concern. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/unconcern#Etymology)
bequeathed (verb)	leave or give by will after one's death	*Neither knew they had bequeathed to the cook the company of another shark, or perhaps the same shark.*	
carpets (noun)	floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)	*Sometimes they sat down on the sea, near patches of brown sea-weed that rolled over the waves with a movement like carpets on line in a gale.*	
overpowering (adjective)	very strong; impossible to resist	*The oiler plied the oars until his head drooped forward, and the overpowering sleep blinded him.*	
dejection (noun)	a state of melancholy depression	*The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down.*	“dejection”: Origin: Old French dejection; earlier Latin dejectio (“a casting down”). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/dejection#Etymology)
	a private talk		

conference (noun)		*A conference was held in the boat. "Well," said the captain, "if no help is coming, we might better try a run through the surf right away.*	
disadvantage (noun)	the quality of having an inferior or less favorable position	*A singular disadvantage of the sea lies in the fact that after successfully surmounting one wave you discover that there is another behind it just as important and just as nervously anxious to do something effective in the way of swamping boats.*	“disadvantage”: Origin: Old French desavantage. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/disadvantage#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with nature's indifference?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many men are in the dinghy? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Four
2. Who is injured? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: The captain
3. What do the men see on shore that raises false hope? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A man waving and a bus or omnibus
4. Who drowns in the surf? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: The oiler, Billie
5. What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Interpreters of the sea
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Open Boat” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run the surf; the oiler, the strongest, drowns. The survivors feel they can now be 'interpreters' of the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Open Boat”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.

8. Where and when does “The Open Boat” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.” What does “paddling” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: paddling: propel with a paddle.
10. Reread: “Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.” What does “oarsman” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · CAIE-9695.AO1] Look for: oarsman: someone who rows a boat.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Open Boat” suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. On imagery: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring…”, why might Crane have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Open Boat”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Open Boat” set up that the rest of The Open Boat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph

243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does theme appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with nature's indifference? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.' How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Open Boat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. On point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Credit any

position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Open Boat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to brotherhood: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Crane need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. On point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Open Boat” treats brotherhood against an indifferent sea with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Open Boat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve nature's indifference? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207):

Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Stephen Crane about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound _____ and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down.”
   Word bank: oarsman, epithets, paddling, dejection
   Key: dejection
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How many men are in the dinghy?
   A. Six
   B. Two
   C. Four
   D. Ten
   Key: C (Four)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who drowns in the surf?
   A. The captain
   B. The cook
   C. The correspondent
   D. The oiler, Billie
   Key: D (The oiler, Billie)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is injured?
   A. The correspondent
   B. The captain
   C. The oiler
   D. The cook
   Key: B (The captain)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Sometimes they sat down on the sea, near patches of brown sea-weed that rolled over the waves with a movement like _____ on line in a gale.”
   Word bank: oarsman, epithets, paddling, carpets
   Key: carpets
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the men see on shore that raises false hope?
   A. A fire
   B. A man waving and a bus or omnibus
   C. A lighthouse keeper rowing out
   D. A ship
   Key: B (A man waving and a bus or omnibus)
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Open Boat, paragraph 207: “But she was _____, flatly indifferent”
   Key: indifferent
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The oiler plied the oars until his head drooped forward, and the _____ sleep blinded him.” Word bank: overpowering, epithets, oarsman, paddling
   Key: overpowering
9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Neither knew they had _____ to the cook the company of another shark, or perhaps the same shark.” Word bank: oarsman, paddling, epithets, bequeathed
   Key: bequeathed
10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Open Boat, paragraph 243: “they felt that they could then be _____”
    Key: interpreters
11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Open Boat”?
    A. Science that poisons love
    B. Hope created by an act of sacrifice
    C. The foolishness of wishing to be young again
    D. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea
    Key: D (Brotherhood against an indifferent sea)
12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Focus on survival.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Theme.
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Open Boat”? Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.
    A. Irony
    B. Metaphor
    C. Point of view
    D. Theme

Key: C (Point of view)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Open Boat”? Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.

    A. Setting

    B. Plot

    C. Metaphor

    D. Imagery

    Key: D (Imagery)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Focus on survival.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The ending.

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207).
    Sample answer: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Theme.

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be?

    A. Interpreters of the sea

    B. Heroes

    C. Sailors again

    D. Rich men

    Key: A (Interpreters of the sea)

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how nature's indifference develops from an earlier story to “The Open Boat”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: nature is "flatly indifferent."

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.”, what does “epithets” most nearly mean?

    A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    B. someone who rows a boat

    C. propel with a paddle

D. lack of worry or interest

Key: A (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line ""All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.", what does "paddling" most nearly mean?

A. propel with a paddle

B. someone who rows a boat

C. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

D. lack of worry or interest

Key: A (propel with a paddle)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.", what does "oarsman" most nearly mean?

A. propel with a paddle

B. someone who rows a boat

C. lack of worry or interest

D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

Key: B (someone who rows a boat)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "It is, perhaps, plausible that a man in this situation, impressed with the unconcern of the universe, should see the innumerable flaws of his life and have them taste wickedly in his mind and wish for another chance.", what does "unconcern" most nearly mean?

A. lack of worry or interest

B. someone who rows a boat

C. propel with a paddle

D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

Key: A (lack of worry or interest)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 9, 10, 1, 2, 3, 4, 7, 6, 12, 11, 13, 14, 17, 18, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	20, 8, 10, 9, 1, 6, 2, 3, 11, 12, 13, 15, 17, 18, 19, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 6, 10, 3, 20, 9, 7, 11, 13, 12, 18, 17, 14, 15, 22, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 4, 8, 3, 9, 2, 11, 13, 12, 14, 17, 15, 18, 19, 21, 22	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 23, 3, 10, 2, 11, 12, 13, 18, 14, 15, 17, 22, 21, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	24, 5, 9, 25, 2, 12, 13, 11, 18, 14, 15, 17, 22, 21, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	24, 4, 9, 26, 8, 13, 12, 11, 17, 18, 14, 15, 16, 22, 19, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	1, 3, 2, 8, 25, 12, 11, 13, 14, 18, 15, 17, 19, 22, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	9, 4, 7, 3, 20, 13, 12, 11, 18, 17, 15, 14, 19, 21, 22, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	5, 4, 24, 6, 9, 13, 12, 11, 17, 14, 15, 18, 16, 21, 19, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Open Boat,” how does Crane show brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): In The Open Boat, how does Crane develop the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Open Boat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Open Boat suggests about brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Stephen Crane uses point of view in The Open Boat to complicate the reader's understanding of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Situate The Open Boat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of brotherhood against an indifferent sea responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Read The Open Boat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of brotherhood against an indifferent sea follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Open Boat and its treatment

of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Open Boat as evidence for a larger claim about brotherhood against an indifferent sea in The Open Boat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Open Boat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Open Boat.

SAT-style questions

1. *Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “epithets” most nearly mean?

   A. the quality of having an inferior or less favorable position

   B. a state of melancholy depression

   C. a private talk

   D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

2. *The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down. The mind of the master of a vessel is rooted deep in the timbers of her, though he command for a day or a decade, and this captain had on him the stern impression of a scene in the grays of dawn of seven turned faces, and later a stump of a top-mast with a white ball on it that slashed to and fro at the waves, went low and lower, and down. Thereafter there was something strange in his voice. Although steady, it was deep with mourning, and of a quality beyond oration or tears.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Open Boat”?

   A. Friendship tested by duty

   B. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

   C. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   D. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

SAT key: 1. D (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase); 2. C (Brotherhood against an indifferent sea)

Unit test

The Open Boat: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The oiler plied the oars until his head drooped forward, and the _____ sleep blinded him.” Word bank: overpowering, epithets, oarsman, paddling
   Key: overpowering
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Open Boat, paragraph 207: “But she was _____, flatly indifferent”
   Key: indifferent
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound _____ and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down.”
   Word bank: oarsman, epithets, paddling, dejection
   Key: dejection
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who drowns in the surf?
   A. The captain
   B. The cook
   C. The correspondent
   D. The oiler, Billie

   Key: D (The oiler, Billie)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is injured?
   A. The correspondent
   B. The captain
   C. The oiler
   D. The cook

   Key: B (The captain)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How many men are in the dinghy?
   A. Six
   B. Two
   C. Four

D. Ten

Key: C (Four)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be?

   A. Interpreters of the sea

   B. Heroes

   C. Sailors again

   D. Rich men

   Key: A (Interpreters of the sea)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the men see on shore that raises false hope?

   A. A fire

   B. A man waving and a bus or omnibus

   C. A lighthouse keeper rowing out

   D. A ship

   Key: B (A man waving and a bus or omnibus)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Neither knew they had _____ to the cook the company of another shark, or perhaps the same shark.” Word bank: oarsman, paddling, epithets, bequeathed

   Key: bequeathed

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Sometimes they sat down on the sea, near patches of brown sea-weed that rolled over the waves with a movement like _____ on line in a gale.”

    Word bank: oarsman, epithets, paddling, carpets

    Key: carpets

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Open Boat, paragraph 243: “they felt that they could then be _____”

    Key: interpreters

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Theme.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Open Boat”?

    A. Science that poisons love

    B. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

    C. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

    D. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

    Key: D (Brotherhood against an indifferent sea)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Focus on survival.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Open Boat”? Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.

    A. Setting

B. Plot

C. Metaphor

D. Imagery

Key: D (Imagery)

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Open Boat”? Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.

    A. Irony

    B. Metaphor

    C. Point of view

    D. Theme

    Key: C (Point of view)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The ending.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Focus on survival.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207).

    Sample answer: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Theme.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.”, what does “paddling” most nearly mean?

    A. propel with a paddle

    B. someone who rows a boat

    C. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

    D. lack of worry or interest

    Key: A (propel with a paddle)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.”, what does “oarsman” most nearly mean?

    A. propel with a paddle

    B. someone who rows a boat

C. lack of worry or interest

D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

Key: B (someone who rows a boat)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how nature's indifference develops from an earlier story to “The Open Boat”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: nature is "flatly indifferent."

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.”, what does “epithets” most nearly mean?

A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

B. someone who rows a boat

C. propel with a paddle

D. lack of worry or interest

Key: A (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It is, perhaps, plausible that a man in this situation, impressed with the unconcern of the universe, should see the innumerable flaws of his life and have them taste wickedly in his mind and wish for another chance.”, what does “unconcern” most nearly mean?

A. lack of worry or interest

B. someone who rows a boat

C. propel with a paddle

D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

Key: A (lack of worry or interest)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	11, 10, 2, 8, 1, 7, 5, 9, 4, 3, 6, 12, 14, 13, 19, 17, 16, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 10, 11, 1, 9, 4, 8, 3, 2, 6, 13, 12, 14, 17, 19, 15, 21, 20	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	3, 1, 5, 8, 7, 9, 2, 6, 4, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 15, 16, 18, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	8, 1, 11, 5, 9, 2, 7, 4, 12, 13, 14, 16, 15, 19, 17, 18, 20, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	22, 1, 3, 9, 23, 4, 10, 12, 13, 14, 17, 16, 15, 19, 20, 18, 21, 24	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 1, 8, 25, 6, 7, 3, 12, 14, 13, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 24, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	9, 23, 25, 8, 11, 22, 5, 13, 12, 14, 15, 19, 17, 16, 20, 18, 21, 24	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior		

	4, 11, 10, 1, 22, 23, 25, 14, 13, 12, 15, 16, 19, 17, 20, 21, 24, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	11, 3, 6, 23, 25, 2, 5, 13, 14, 12, 16, 17, 19, 15, 24, 18, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 11, 25, 3, 26, 23, 2, 13, 14, 12, 19, 17, 15, 16, 20, 21, 24, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Open Boat: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Stephen Crane develops nature's indifference across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Open Boat and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to brotherhood.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Open Boat. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Open Boat finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of survival. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Nature's indifference

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about nature's indifference. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops nature's indifference across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature's indifference. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature's indifference, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of nature's indifference in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature's indifference in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature's indifference in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature's indifference in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Brotherhood

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about brotherhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops brotherhood in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops brotherhood across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of brotherhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of brotherhood in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of brotherhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of brotherhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on brotherhood in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on brotherhood in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about brotherhood in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on brotherhood in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Survival

Scaffolded support (600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about survival. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops survival in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops survival across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of survival. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of survival in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of survival, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of survival in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on survival in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on survival in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about survival in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Cambridge International: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on survival in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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